

PREMISE DELTA v0.5 · THE TRUSTING FORGERY, THIRD CUT · 2026-09-09 (DRAFT until Stephen has read it)

Fifth delta against premise v8.1 and spine v1.4 with amendments v1.5 to v1.8. History: v0.1 and v0.2 rejected by two adversaries each; v0.3 (2026-09-08) REWORK from Fable and REJECT from GPT, ten findings walked and answered on 2026-09-09; v0.4 (2026-09-09) REWORK from both, Fable stating that "the device itself survives every front", nine findings walked and answered the same day (...-v0.4-disposition-2026-09-09.md). This document is v0.4 with those nine answers built in. Assembled at Stephen's housekeep from rulings he accepted; he has not yet read it as a whole. When he has, it goes to both adversaries fresh. Premise v8.1 remains in force until it survives and Stephen rules.

A note to the reviewer: sections 8 and 9 record the two previous rounds' findings and the answers now built in. Attack the answers. A finding re-raised without engaging its answer does not count.

1. The device

Before (v8.1, ruled). A dead woman's accusation tears four friends apart. Her key letter: I think one of you is planning to kill me. The locker letter, forged: I know. Chapter 7: dead women don't get surer.

After (v0.5). A woman who trusted four people completely asked them, from behind a padlocked door, to find out who had been getting into her house. She said it was none of them. Within a month the four were sure it was one of them. Violet never accuses anyone. The accusation is built at Ruby's kitchen table by the four themselves, out of true things, and the true things were chosen by the one of them who killed her. Brad does not forge her fear. He forges her trust, keeps her voice and her instruction, and salts the list so that four honest, frightened, competent people, doing what she asked, arrive at Liam. What lets them cross out her clearance is not a character reading: it is a locked house, two glasses on the side, a man's back in a lane, a spare key exactly where it should be, and her own sentence that only the four knew where it lived.

Everything downstream holds as ruled: the room lands on Liam, Margo keeps her silence, Brad vanishes off Kestrel Head on Day 60, Margo dies there on Day 214, the survivors accuse each other to the police, the police look properly and find nothing, Ruby talks to the Gazette, Ally begins.

2. Violet

Forty-four, the best judge of a hand on the coast, and she writes everything down, dated. No will: a woman with a solicitor and death-triggered envelopes who kept meaning to make one, so her sister, as next of kin, will administer everything, which is the irony of the fight over their mother's house.

This autumn, two things inside her own house. Her tobacco, two a day rolled from the tin under the stairs among the paints and the garden concentrates, comes up stained through the paper; the lid is loose; the capped bottle on the shelf above has moved six inches or has not. She bins the tobacco that day and does not smoke from that tin again. And a gilded alphabet panel comes down out of her workshop roof with a ceiling board: her own alphabet, better than she has ever done it, signed with a mark that is not a name.

She carries the panel round the trade asking whose hand it is: the café, the cinema, two other signwriters. Two say yours, in a very good year, and one of them asks the obvious question: have you shown your lad? So, last, she shows Brad. He looks at it a long time and says yours, and names the R. Three yours. She stops asking. What she tells herself is that it cannot be his because she never taught him leaf and he never asked; what she writes is that everyone says it is hers and she did not make it. The other three never see it: they are not lettering people, and by the time she next sees them she has stopped asking. Nobody in town knows Brad can gild; his boat names are painted, and the leaf work at the yard was always hers.

She believes someone with her spare key has been in her house. She also believes, on alternate days, that she is imagining it. She does not suspect any of the four for a second, and the reason she does not call them is not fear of them: she has nothing to show them but a loose lid and a panel three people have told her is her own, and she would rather be laughed at after she is gone than watched while she is here. So she does what she does with everything. She writes it down. Her store at the slip boatsheds is one of the old brick boat stores: a bay, a steel door on a shrouded hasp, nothing visible from outside, where she kept her hull kit. She moves the kit to the van, changes the padlock (a closed-shackle marine padlock), has four keys cut on Lantern Street and keeps none, so that nothing on her ring leads to the door. The store's rent is a year ahead in cash and the sheds hold no next of kin. She locks the letter behind the door with the panel and her mother, and lodges four bare notes with her solicitor to be posted after her funeral. He asks; she makes a joke about her sister. Then she gets on, calmer, because it is out of her head. She does not expect it to be needed.

3. The three letters, sketched (Fable writes prose, blind)

The key letter (genuine; four identical copies; posted Saturday Day 12; three by home delivery, one to a post office box). If you've got this, I'm dead, and I'm sorry about the timing. Go to my store at the boatsheds by the slip. The padlock's new and these four keys are the only ones. Go together, all four of you, and read what's there together. Violet. Nothing else: no trust stated, no fear, no police, nothing that dates the letter behind the door.

The locker letter (genuine; dated Day -19; Brad reads it at 07:20 on Day 14; burned in her sink that afternoon with his drafts and the debt book). It isn't any of you four, and I'd know. Someone with my key has been in my house, or I have started imagining things, and I cannot tell which, and both frighten me. Only you four know where the spare lives. The tin: the two a day she lies about, the stain through the paper, the loose lid, the bottle on the shelf above; I don't know whether I did that; I've thrown the tobacco out. The panel: the leak, the board, her own alphabet done better than she can do it, a mark for a name; Brad says it's mine, everyone says it's mine, I didn't make it; and if I didn't, somebody has been in my roof. Mum, on the shelf in the back bedroom, facing the door one morning when I leave her facing the window; I've put her in here. Then: each of you write down everything odd you've noticed this year, about each other and about me, however small, and read the four lists together at one table. Then the police, with something in your hands. Write legibly. Brad reads it and knows what the room never will: pooled, the odd things name him (Ruby holds the marathon he called a wedding; Liam heard him price the van from the crane cab; Margo holds the debt and the calling-in), and the panel names a gilder.

The locker letter (forged; dated Day -19 as she dated everything; what the four read at nine that night). Her paper, her pen, her hand; drafted from Day 1 at his own bench from what her book said she had noticed, and conformed to her true letter in two hours at hers on Day 14. Her frame, kept: it isn't any of you four, and I'd know; someone with my key has been in my house, or I'm imagining it, which frightens me more; only you four know where the spare lives. Her reason for the scale, in her voice: I don't think I'm going

to die. I think I'm going to be sixty and embarrassed. But I'm putting this where it can't be got at, because if I'm wrong nobody needs to know, and if I'm right you'll want to know what I noticed. If I'd told you now you'd have sat in my kitchen with a torch and I'd never have heard the end of it. The object: I have put Mum in here with this. One morning last month she was facing the door, and I leave her facing the window. Somebody has been in the back bedroom, or I have started moving things and forgetting. Either way she is not staying on a shelf for whoever it is to stand and look at. Keep her where all four of you can see her until this is sorted. Her instruction, kept. Then, "since I'm asking you to, here's mine", bare fact only, nothing she was not present for: Liam has owned a third of the yard for eight years and lets the town think he's staff. Liam asked in March and again in July to take Mum out to the point on his boat; I said no both times. Brad told us a wedding in the spring and ran a marathon; I saw his time. His one addition: not the police. I've nothing they'd act on and I won't have them in your lives over a shelf. You four can do what they won't. Her close, kept: read this together, be careful, write legibly.

What he cut: the tin (a poisoning in her hand sends a nurse to the police through any ban), the panel (it names a gilder), every word about money (Margo holds the names and sums). What he kept that he could have cut: her sentence about the spare, because it is true and it closes the room on itself. What he added: the ban, and three true things that lean one way. The lean is in the choosing, never in a sentence.

4. Brad on the night, and the fourteen days

He comes about the money; she goes up for the debt book; the landing. In the twenty minutes he waits he reads her book of everything, and in her hand, dated: padlock changed, four keys cut on Lantern Street, none kept, four envelopes lodged with the solicitor, letter and Mum and the thing in the store. He learns that a letter exists and where, and what she had been noticing, not what she concluded. He takes the book, because it is his exemplar and it names his debt. Out by the back door at 22:30, latched; the neighbour at N^o14 sees a man's back and nothing in his hands; the book is in the rucksack he brought for it. Two glasses of wine stay on the side.

He does not go near the store for fourteen days, and it is the least-cost choice for this man. Nobody else can open it before the keys arrive: no fifth key exists, the sheds hold no next of kin to cut a lock, and a brick bay with a steel door on a shrouded hasp has no partition, roof or hinge to go through. A cut, picked or forced lock is the one event in the story that makes the police look: four people with keys, an empty store, days after a letter told them to read what was there together. His method from the tin to the stairs is that nothing is ever visibly wrong. The sheds are worked from first light, so an early visit has the same witness on any day and a torch at two in the morning is what gets remembered. His own locker in the same corridor is a reason to be there at seven, and his PO box gives him seven. From Day 1 he drafts at his own bench from the book's list. On Day 14 he reads her true letter, confirms his draft in two hours at her bench, burns the drafts, the true letter and the book in her sink, and puts the forgery and her mother in the store by mid-afternoon. The panel goes into his own locker, where it sits until Day 60. The boat owner sees a signwriter carrying a board between two doors at the sheds where she kept her kit.

5. The room, week by week (replaces spine rows 14 to 60 in substance)

Day 14, 21:00. Torches, the padlock, a letter in her hand and her mother beside it. Margo: she's brought her mum. Brad hands Ruby the letter and lets Liam be the one who reaches. Liam carries the tube to Ruby's car, footwell not boot. Read that night at Ruby's table. The first response is relief, and then the shame of relief.

Liam explains March and July the moment they are read: it had been four years; I thought if somebody offered she wouldn't have to be the one to decide. Ruby names the one line that did not sound like Vi: the police one. They decide, four of them, that Violet's sister hears nothing until they know what they are looking at, because telling her means telling her that Violet kept their mother from her for four years and lied about the point. Weekly meetings agreed. The tube on Ruby's sideboard, label to the wall because that is how Liam set it down.

Day 15. The key question, because they are competent adults, and the outward look, done in one evening because her life was small enough to audit in one evening. Liam answers the key because he found her: front locked, back latched, the spare still in the meter box, and two glasses of wine on the side. Nobody else: no cleaner, no lodger, no tradesman (Liam did every repair in that house, including the catch), a smart meter nobody reads, a sister four years away who has never been inside, and four people who were her whole week. And the letter, in her hand: only you four know where the spare lives, beside it isn't any of you. Number 14 told Liam at the funeral about a man's back in the lane at half past ten. They look outward, and there is nobody there, and that is the worst thing that could have happened to them.

Meeting 1 (Day 19). The lists begin. Liam confirms the third of the yard; the letter has told one truth and earned the rest. Where were we on the Monday night: Ruby on shift; Margo at home, alone, as on every night that is not a second Sunday; Liam alone at the yard; Brad at home, on foot, alone, which is the truth minus the walk. Nobody has an alibi and the quiet man has the least. Ruby says the line the room needs, and nobody answers it, because answering means saying Vi fell alone with two glasses out: she thought she'd know, and she's dead.

Meeting 2 (Day 26). Everything odd about Violet. The shelf. Who had been in the back bedroom this year. Liam, honestly: once, the window catch, spring. Margo underlines Spring.

Meeting 3 (Day 33). March and July, again, now beside the catch, the key and the second glass. Brad: that's Liam, he'd have thought that. Ruby: Vi didn't write down things that didn't bother her. Nobody looks at the sideboard. The room hears an ordinary explanation given quickly as one given before; it hears a kindness about her mother as an interest in the back bedroom. That is what a frightened room does to the quiet man, and it is what the later chapters indict the room for.

Meetings 4 and 5 (Days 40, 47). The lists worked against each other; Ruby drives; Brad defends Liam each time, reasonably, and loses. By Day 47 it has landed on Liam without one line of the letter having said it. Margo, alone at the sideboard for as long as it takes Ruby to say goodbye upstairs: a quarter turn of the label, and back.

Days 45 to 53. Margo. She was never the estate's accountant: the sister uses her own solicitor and her own accountant. On Day 8 Margo helped the sister with paperwork, which was handing over Violet's business books, and noticed the debt book was not among them (told the sister; shrug; nobody else knew it existed). The cash loan never entered the business books. Around Day 45 the sister's accountant rings her: the café says Violet was calling in money; anything owed to her? Margo answers, truthfully and narrowly: nothing in the books. That night she reads the letter again for what is not there. A letter in Violet's hand that lists everything odd about her year and never mentions the money she spent the autumn calling in; the debt book gone from a locked house; at a table convened to list everything odd, the one man who was called in has said nothing, and he is the man defending Liam; and Margo has just done for the sister exactly what the letter did for the room. It is a reading, not a proof, and she cannot take it anywhere: Violet's confidence, an omission is not evidence, and the man it points at is the one arguing for the man the room has chosen. **Day 54, meeting 6:** she stops arguing with Brad and stops looking at the other two. Brad, who has read her true letter and knows exactly

what Margo holds, is the only one in the room who can read that silence, and he does. **Day 60:** Kestrel Head, as ruled. From there as ruled.

6. Chapter 7: a suspect turn, honestly

By chapter 4 Ally holds, from the boat owner via the Tip Line and unaired, that "the young one" was at Violet's store at twenty past seven on the Monday morning (he knew which door was hers; she lettered his boat; he read it at the time as her pupil collecting her kit). By chapter 6 she holds the panel from the two signwriters and the calling-in from the café. In chapter 7 Ruby gives her the envelope: the solicitor's covering slip and postmark. Four envelopes posted together on the Saturday, three to home addresses and one to a box number. A box is cleared first thing; home delivery came after work. One of the four held his key by seven, and the boat owner saw him use it at twenty past. The letter the four read together at nine that night had been in his hands since morning. Chapter 7 claims no more than that: the man who defended Liam every week deserves the investigation nobody gave him. The omissions, the kind line and the one sentence that did not sound like Vi are why the listener believes it; they are not proof, and Ally says so. Proof of the forgery arrives where the spine has it: the arrest on Day 333, the panel on his wall, the deckhand's papers.

7. What changes, what does not

Changes. The premise device. The cold open's middle (two versions to the three blind readers, section 10). Chapter 1 packages 4 to 6; chapter 2 packages 2, 3, 8 and 10; chapter 7. Spine: A1 (Day 0 debt book; the ashes; no board; the store's construction; no fifth key; the store's rent; intestacy); B1 rows 5a/5b retired and new rows for the ashes, Liam's two requests, the sister's belief, the day Violet shows Brad the panel; B3 rows 25 to 30; C2 Brad (Day 0 knowledge, drafting from Day 1, the panel in his locker); C5 Margo (never engaged; the accountant's question); D2/D3; R16 retired. The key letter ruled 2026-09-05 is void; the bare note replaces it. Rulings withdrawn: teacher's pride (2026-09-08, 7); the probate engagement (vo.4). Terminology per v1.8.

Does not change. The motive (the van money, called in for the fight with the sister; lent on no paper by Violet's choice). The panel (her alphabet, his mark) and the dosed tin as what frightened her into the store. Brad's PO box, dawn read and same-night swap (v1.7). His nine hundred days, the deckhand's papers, the vanish, the arrest under the deckhand's name on Day 333. Margo's six-week silence as the load-bearing lock, and her death. The survivors' fear of each other, the police look (row 25, R27), the Gazette, Ally's ten weeks. All four decisions. The notch. The two survivors' refusal to name what stood beside the letter.

8. The vo.3 round: ten findings and their answers (still in force)

#	Finding	Answer
1	Brad defeats the padlock on Day 0	Section 4
2	Chapter 7 is an inference from a "starter list"	Section 6: the box number; "starter list" gone
3	The machinery's scale; the tin cut; the solicitor; pride	Sections 2 and 3; pride now withdrawn in favour of showing Brad
4	Margo: Day 8; Day 19 to 51; Brad kills over a silence	Section 5, as reworked in the vo.4 round
5	The key question; Liam's line; the arithmetic	Section 5: Day 15; Ruby's line; within a month
6	The sister and the ashes	Section 2 and the sweep; Liam found her on Day 1
7	Liam can contradict "he didn't ask why"	Section 3: bare fact only
8	Ruby to Del on Day 15	Row 25 and R27; either branch survives

#	Finding	Answer
9	"The ninth"	No date for the shelf; the letter itself is dated
10	The first minute	Section 10: a test

9. The vo.4 round: nine findings and their answers (attack these)

#	Finding (Fable / GPT)	Answer built into vo.5
1	Margo's duty runs to the executor (both; GPT's driver)	Section 5: intestacy; the sister administers with her own people; Margo never engaged; her Day 8 is a handover; the accountant's question around Day 45 is the arrival; "nothing in the books" is her choice with a cost.
2	The suspect pool closed by assertion (GPT fatal)	Section 5, Day 15: her own sentence about the spare, kept verbatim in the forgery; the outward audit done in one evening and empty.
3	The fourteen days: fifth key, executor's cutters, the book, the exposed day (Fable); the enclosure (GPT)	Sections 2 and 4: brick bay, steel door, shrouded hasp, no partition; no fifth key, kit to the van; rent a year ahead, no next of kin, the sister cuts the lock on Day 82 as canon; the book taken Day 0 and burned Day 14; drafting from Day 1, two hours at her bench.
4	No fact turns a fall into a killing; the man in the lane (Fable)	Section 5: two glasses on the side; N°14's man at 22:30; the alibi round at meeting one with Brad's answer written.
5	Chapter 7 is a suspect turn, not a forgery turn (both); which padlock (Fable)	Section 6: claimed as a suspect turn only; proof at the arrest; the boat owner knew her door.
6	Violet and the trade (both)	Section 2: she shows Brad last; he says yours; three yours; teacher's pride withdrawn.
7	The sister told about the ashes after Day 14 (both)	Section 5, Day 14: the four decide the sister hears nothing until they know what they are looking at; they tell nobody about the letter, as canon.
8	The undated letter (GPT)	Section 3: dated Day -19 as she dated everything; only the shelf is vague.
9	The panel's exit at 07:20 (Fable)	Section 4: into his own locker in the same corridor until Day 60.

10. The first minute: the test

Two versions of the open's middle go to the three blind readers with the ruled vo.4 open as control. Version A: she said someone had been getting in; she said it wasn't any of them; she said she might be imagining it; she wasn't; she was dead; within a month the four she trusted with the only keys were sure it was one of them; only two of them are still alive. Version B brings "only two of them are still alive" and the tin's image inside the first sixty seconds. One question at the minute mark, unprompted: what are you afraid of right now. Nothing is ruled until the readers answer.

11. The new and changed facts, swept

Fact	Holder	Earliest competent action	Outcome	Holds?
Intestacy; the sister administers	Sister, her solicitor	Administer; ask Violet's accountant	Margo hands over the business books; asked around Day 45, says nothing in the books, which is true	Yes
Margo's note and the missing book	Margo	Tell the sister's accountant; tell the room; tell Del	Not engaged; a note of a conversation; Violet's confidence; a book nobody else knew existed; an omission is not evidence	Yes, and it costs her

Fact	Holder	Earliest competent action	Outcome	Holds?
Her sentence about the spare, in the forgery	The four	Read it beside her clearance	The contradiction is hers; the room chooses the fear	Yes: it is the room's turn
The two glasses; the man in the lane	Liam; №14	Tell the room	Someone was with her that night; the alibi round; nobody has one	Yes
No fifth key; the store's rent; the brick bay	Brad; the sister; the sheds	Reach the store before Day 14	Nobody can, and nobody has a reason to cut a lock	Yes
Violet shows Brad the panel	Brad	Act on it	He does: the acceleration from Day -40 as ruled, now from her mouth	Yes
The ashes kept from the sister	The four	Tell her	They decide not to, on night one, for a stated reason; canon has them telling nobody about the letter	Yes, as a choice with a cost
The letter dated Day -19	The four; later the solicitor	Check it	The lodging on Day -18 corroborates it	Yes
The panel in Brad's locker Day 14 to 60	Boat owner	Notice	A signwriter carrying a board between two doors	Yes
Liam's two requests; the meter box; the forged ban; the four bare notes	As the v0.3 round	As the v0.3 round	As the v0.3 round	Yes

PROMPT FOR CHATGPT (paste everything below this line)

You are the adversarial reviewer for a true-crime mystery in production. This premise change has been attacked twice and reworked twice on the findings; sections 8 and 9 list those findings and the answers now built in. Your job is to break the third cut, not to improve it. Read the delta above in full. Attack on six fronts. For each front, find the strongest objection you can, state it plainly, say whether it is fatal, serious or cosmetic, and say what would have to be true for it to be answered. A finding from a previous round re-raised without engaging its answer does not count; if you think an answer fails, say exactly where it fails. Do not soften. Do not propose alternative stories. No scores, no percentages. No em dashes.

The fronts:

1. **Margo, un-engaged.** She hands over the books on Day 8, is asked around Day 45 whether anything was owed, and says nothing in the books. Find the person who asks her the next question, and the day, and say what she answers.
2. **The room's closed pool.** It closes on Violet's own sentence (only you four know where the spare lives) and a one-evening audit of a small life. Find the outsider the audit misses, or the reason a competent person at the table refuses to let her sentence outweigh her clearance.
3. **Violet shows Brad.** She shows him last and he says yours. Find what a competent Violet does the day after, and what a competent Brad does the day after that, and say which of them ends the episode early.
4. **The fourteen days, third time.** The store is a brick bay with a steel door on a shrouded hasp; there is no fifth key; the rent is a year ahead; Brad drafts from Day 1. Find the remaining act, by anyone, that opens that door before Day 14 without making anything visibly wrong.

5. **The two glasses.** The room's fact that turns a fall into a killing is two glasses of wine on the side and a man's back in the lane. Find what the police did with those on Day 1, and why the room can use them when the coroner could not.
6. **The whole.** Take the device as it now stands and find the earliest competent action by any person in the story, on any fact, that ends the episode before its time. If there is none, say so.

End with one paragraph: PROCEED, PROCEED WITH CHANGES, TEST BEFORE COMMITTING, REWORK or REJECT, with your confidence and the single finding that most drives the verdict.